

Tremarctos ornatus

Spectacled bear



Location W. South America

Length 4¼–6¼ft (1.3–1.9 m)
Tail Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Weight 130–390 lb (60–175 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



South America's only bear, and its largest land mammal after the tapirs, the spectacled or Andean bear is also the most arboreal of the family. Playing a prominent role in the folklore and mythology of many Andean peoples, its multitude of local names include oso achupayero (bromeliad-eating bear), yura mateo (white-fronted bear), yanapuma (black puma), and ucucu (after one of its rare vocalizations). The species once occupied habitats from coastal desert to high-elevation grassland, but human presence increasingly limits it to cloud forests at 3,300–8,900 ft (1,000–2,700 m). Mainly vegetarian, its massive jaw muscles and cheek teeth grind the toughest plants. For example, low-growing plants are simply torn up and chewed, despite cactus spines or leaf barbs on puya bromeliads. A common tree-feeding technique is to edge along a branch, bending other



CUBS IN THEIR DEN
Newborn spectacled bear cubs, like other baby bears, are tiny, each weighing only 12 oz (325 g). Most are born between December and February.

branches to bring fruit within reach. These bears may also create a simple tree platform, 16 ft (5 m) or more across, for feeding and resting. Most matings occur from April to June, but may happen at almost any time so that the birth corresponds with greatest food availability. The pair stay together for 1–2 weeks. The cubs' eyes open at 42 days and they may leave the den, in a hollow among rocks or tree roots, by 3 months. The cubs stay with the mother for 2 years, learning about feeding methods, food types, and threats. As with other bears, the male plays no part in rearing the cubs and, if he encounters them by chance, may attack and kill them.

CROPS AND CONFLICT

The diet of the spectacled bear, one of the most herbivorous of bears, includes a huge range of fruit, as well as bromeliads, bulbs of wild orchids and similar flowers, palm shoots and leaf stalks, and, in drier areas, grass stems and cacti. Animal foods include insects, birds, eggs, small mammals, and carrion. Raids on crops, especially corn, and occasional attacks on livestock provoke revenge killings by farmers.

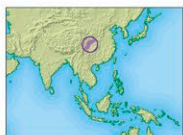


SPECTACLES
The creamy white eye markings vary from complete circles to "eyebrows" above or "tear-drops" below, and allow identification of individual bears.

usually black, but occasionally red-brown fur

Ailuropoda melanoleuca

Giant panda



Location E. Asia

Length 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
Tail 4–6 in (10–15 cm)
Weight 155–280 lb (70–125 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



Instantly recognizable as the worldwide symbol of conservation, the giant panda's own survival is still far from secure. It has a highly restricted diet—99 percent bamboo, using different parts of the 60 or more bamboo species, taking new shoots in spring, leaves in summer, and stems in winter. Carrion, grubs, and eggs are also eaten when available. Normally solitary, the panda feeds mainly at dawn and dusk, and sleeps in a bamboo thicket. It marks its home ranges with anal gland scents, urine, and claw scratches, avoiding confrontation by using overlapping areas at different times. The female, four-fifths the male's size, indicates readiness to mate by moans, bleats, and barks (11 distinct panda calls have been identified). Males gather, chase, and fight each other for the female. Usually 2 cubs are born

in a den in a hollow tree or rocky cave, but one cub is often abandoned. Only 6 in (15 cm) long, and 3½ oz (100 g) in weight, the newborn cubs are nearly naked.



coarse, oily guard (outer) hairs up to 4 in (10 cm) long

CONSERVATION

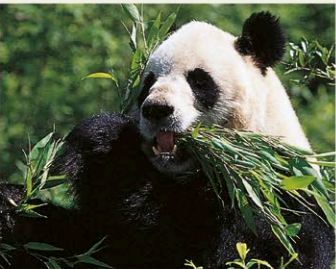
More than 150 pandas are kept in captivity worldwide, and about 10 times that number live in the wild. Their restricted diet and fragmented habitat are still major problems to their survival, but significant progress has been made with captive breeding. Scientists in China can now successfully rear the cubs that the mothers in captivity abandon, by carefully swapping the cubs over every few days.



front limbs more muscled than rear limbs, for climbing

BLACK ON WHITE
The giant panda is white with black ears, oval-shaped eye patches, nose, shoulder "saddle," and limbs. It has erect ears, a broad face, and small eyes.

SIXTH "FINGER"



The giant panda handles bamboo with great dexterity due to an extension of the sesamoid bone in the wrist, which projects as a padlike "false thumb." This can flex and oppose the true thumb (first digit) to grip stems and leaves.